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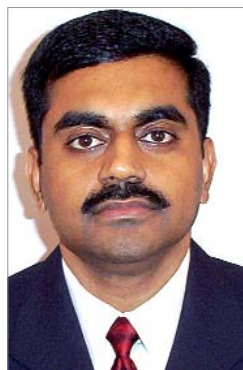
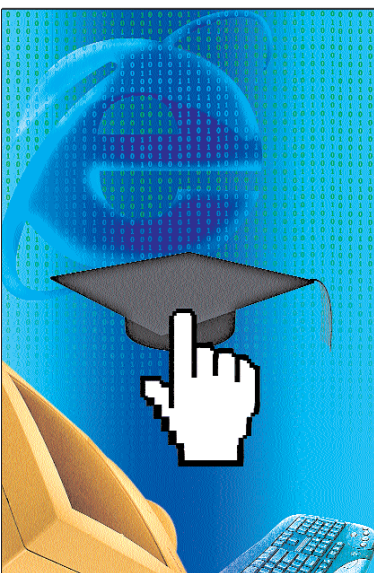
Big names like Harvard University offer online degree programmes, reaching out to students who seek the backing of the brand, but cannot afford the high cost of relocating and the tuition fees of such elite institutions.

The value of an online degree from a reputed college might not compare much with the traditional programme of the institute, but since these institutions can still be selective about their admissions, the brand value would still hold strong.

A concern for students taking online courses is that they aren't in personal contact with their teachers and peers. Thus, they would miss out on learning in person. Moreover, they must look at the selectivity of an institute for an online programme—if the criteria are lax and a large number of students selected, then the brand value of the course is somewhat diluted.

It is still premature to say how online degree holders will fare when compared with their traditional counterparts, but we should see online degrees gaining massive popularity by around 2010.

ACCEPTANCE



Ajay Mallapurkar
Center Head,
Ma Foi Management
Consultants

The bitter truth that candidates with MBAs must deal with today is that they fall in one of only two categories—those who are from a top-rung institute and those who are not. The latter category are practically on a level playing field in the job market. A candidate's resume would reflect his qualification and experience—after that, the interviewer may or may not find out whether the course was done online or not depending on the direction the interview takes. If the candidate's profile speaks for him, the topic may not even come up. What matters is the individual's profile and work experience.

We have a good number of candidates in our database who hold online degrees. I have personally interviewed some of them who hold e-MBAs; I feel that for MBA degrees, at least, an online course lacks the academic rigor and depth that a traditional degree programme offers.

When recommending a candidate to a company, I would focus on the candidate's experience rather than worry about whether the qualification was obtained online or not.



Deepank Jain
Staffing Manager,
Intel India

In India, online degrees are still picking up momentum. The relevance of an online degree would also depend on the field—skills that are required in the technology industry, for example, would require a lot of hands-on training and lab work and an online programme cannot offer the same.

An online degree would be useful in general, non-technical fields like management. At the ground level, though, I don't think that an online degree is a substitute for a degree obtained at traditional institution. Online degrees would help people build high-level skills in their current professions. Students could enrol for online degree programmes as a source of continuous development to enhance specific skills.

At Intel, we are still evaluating the relevance and applicability of such degrees to job profiles in our company. Currently, we look for skills that are highly technical and are supplemented by practical experience.

As told to nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com